



128 Epic Adventures



133 James T Russell



148 Here We Go Again...

Digital Leisure

Technology Beyond Work

Lead Feature

Art For The Asking

Fractals, demonstrating infinite complexity from infinite simplicity, showcase nature itself

Ram Mohan Rao

Seek and ye shall find... but there are fortuitous exceptions. Benoit Mandelbrot sought nothing, but he found. We aren't being historically accurate here, but essentially, Mandelbrot wrote some code and there appeared on his screen something very interesting. (This was way back in 1976.) He thought there was something wrong with the code, so he double-checked. But there it was, staring him in the face—something like the images on the next two pages! (In black and white, though.) He had discovered fractals—mathematical patterns of unmatched beauty,

complex, delirious delights to the eye, stuff that makes you wonder what you've been smoking.

We hate history, so all we'll say is that we're talking about structures arising from *extremely* simple mathematical formulas. And what good are they? Mostly, they're trippy, fun, and addictive. That's why we're writing this—to encourage you to create your own, then preferably print them out on your T-Shirts. But in addition, they're mathematically significant and philosophically profound: fractals are *self-repeating*. They carry themselves within them. Some say fractals describe the structure of the universe: where one thing pervades all, where the smallest reflects the large. As Blake put it: